

going through trying times.

Equipment and preparedness are so low that the army's doctrines like Cold Start, which envisage lighting multi-pronged thrusts into enemy territory, risk being placed in cold storage. No new howitzers to deliver artillery bombardment to precede such a thrust have been bought in over a quarter-century. The tanks which would follow the barrage are night-blind. The replacements for the army's workhorse, the Cheetah light utility helicopters, are long overdue.

Even the million foot soldiers, whose cause Singh so passionately espouses, continue to be equipped with sub-standard clothing and equipment.

Singh has a brief tenure of a little over two years to push all these cases even as he worries about traditional threats—an unstable aggressive Pakistan and looming China. There are other internal challenges. A series of corruption cases in the past few years have exposed the rot at the very top. At least 20 officers of the rank of brigadier and above have been

indicted for various corruption-related cases. In the past three years, there have been at least ten general-level officers indicted in various cases of corruption and moral turpitude.

The culmination was a dubious NOC granted to a builder in the Sukhna military station. The scandal indicted four generals, including the army's senior-most four-star officer, Lt-General Awadesh Prakash (retired). Critics say Singh has been unnecessarily harsh in the Sukhna land case. "A strong leader can use his

Photographs by HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com



## INTERVIEW | GENERAL V.K. SINGH

# "I'll ensure the Army remains clean"

*Army chief General Vijay Kumar Singh spoke to INDIA TODAY Associate Editor SANDEEP UNNITHAN outlining the myriad challenges that face the world's second largest army.*

**Q. What is your message to the country and the army.**

A. My message is clear. We are here to meet all challenges in war and peace. As the nation's army we have our task cut out for us whether it is in war or in peace. We have to ensure all our obligations are met.

**Q. What was the first thing you did after taking over yesterday?**

A. I met a lot of people from all walks of life, including veterans. The approach you take has to have the backing of all the people. My approach is quite simple. We have to build on our strengths and core competencies like selflessness and professionalism.

**Q. A number of recent cases of corruption have dented the image of the army.**

A. The army is the only organisation that has taken action in all such cases. That is the value system we have. We will ensure that we maintain it and give strength to it. We'll also make sure that the organisation remains clean and good and the soldier's image and dignity is well maintained. That is one of the things we want to focus on.

**Q. Modernisation of the army has suffered in the past few years and this has impacted preparedness.**

A. Modernisation is a very long-drawn procedure. Where preparedness of the army is concerned, it is a sum of several other factors including training and not just weapons and equipment.